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RAFALE-M VS THE F/A-18: A TOUGH CHOICE

The Indian Navy mulls which fighter jet to deploy for its new carrier, the INS *Vikrant*, the French or the American one. Strategic considerations will also play a part

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

With the launch of India's indigenous aircraft carrier INS *Vikrant* last year, the search started in earnest for suitable aircraft to be deployed on it. Over the past few years, two aircraft have emerged as the main contenders: the naval version of the French firm Dassault's Rafale fighter jet (Rafale Marine) and the US's F/A-18 Super Hornet from Boeing. India has had a close look at both. In May 2019, 16 fighter jets—eight Indian Navy MiG-29Ks and eight French Rafale-Ms—were up against each other in Exercise Varuna, a naval war game between India and France off the coast of Karnataka. The Rafale-M impressed the Indian Navy with its flawless manoeuvring. Similarly, in late 2020, Boeing demonstrated the F/A-18's suitability for Indian aircraft carriers in the US. At last, in 2022, the two contending multi-role carrier-borne fighters (MRCBF) were called upon for operational demonstration tests at the Indian naval station Hansa in Goa, where INS *Vikrant*'s flight deck was simulated. The Rafale-M went in first, in February 2022, followed by the Super Hornet in July. With the INS *Vikrant* and INS *Vikramaditya*—the Indian